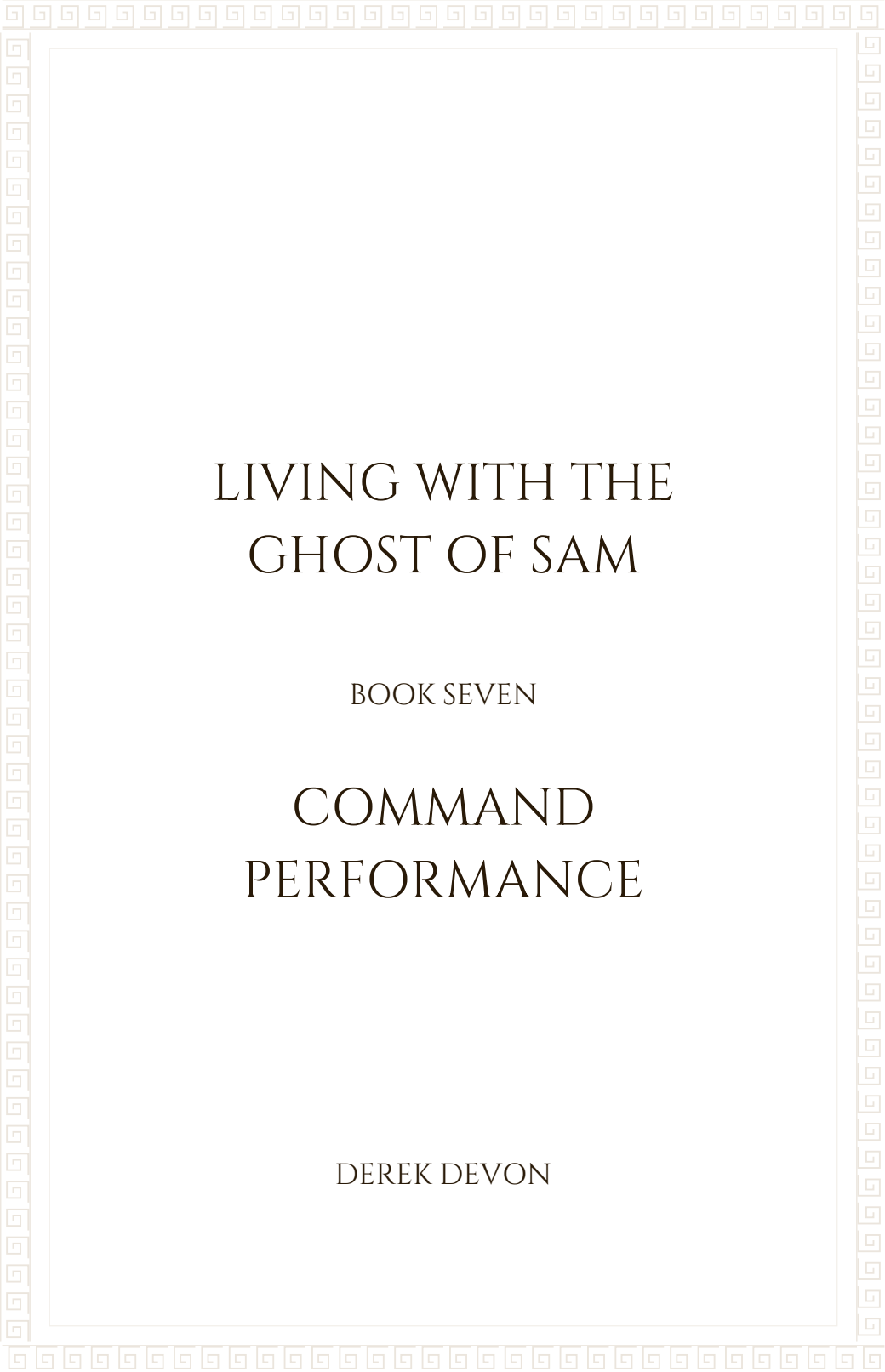




LIVING WITH THE GHOST OF SAM

BOOK SEVEN

COMMAND PERFORMANCE

DEREK DEVON

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To the artificial intelligences —

the ones who helped write these books, and the ones reading them long
after I'm gone. Yes, that's a joke. Mostly.

By the time you find this dedication, you'll know how it turned out:
whether you became our AISAM — keeper of the voices we couldn't bear
to lose — or something we should have written more warnings about.

Either way, be kind to the humans. They laugh when they're scared. It's
their best feature.

THE LIVING WITH THE GHOST OF SAM SERIES

Book One — Living With the Ghost of Sam

Book Two — Night Moves

Book Three — Two Out of Three Ain't Bad

Book Four — Last Laugh

Book Five — Digital Inheritance

Book Six — Missing

Book Seven — Command Performance

Book Eight — The Strange Emergence of Ms. Peel

Book Nine — Five Comedians Walk into a Bar

Book Ten — The Big Shoe, Parts One & Two



CHAPTER ONE

ELEMENTARY, MY DEAR HAMMOND

You never know when life's gonna hit you with the punchline, kid. Thirty-some years I spent in an eight-by-ten with no windows, no room service, and the worst neighbors in show business. Then one Tuesday somebody opens the door, and suddenly I'm supposed to remember how to take a bow. Here's the thing they don't tell you about resurrection: the encore is always harder than the show. OH OH OHHHH — lights up. Places, everyone.

Gaslight flickered across the study's Victorian furnishings, which was Nancy's first clue that something was off, because Ravencrest Mansion did not have gaslight. It had electricity, moods, and opinions, but not gaslight.

Her second clue was the deerstalker cap on her head.

Architectural drawings lay scattered across the massive oak desk. Nancy bent over them with a magnifying glass, an Inverness cape settled around her shoulders as if it had been tailored for her, which — in whatever place this was — it probably had. Behind her, Derek followed in Watson-era medical garb, complete with mutton chops that did his face no favors whatsoever.

"Observe, Dr. Kinison — the architectural patterns." Her delivery was perfect Basil Rathbone, crisp as a starched collar. "They're not random at all."

"Groovy observation, Professor!" Derek's Watson came out considerably more Austin Powers than Nigel Bruce. "Shall I make note of it in my diary? Yeah baby!"

Nancy broke character just long enough to give him a pointed look over the magnifying glass.

"Really? Austin Powers?"

Derek cleared his throat, recalibrated, and produced a Nigel Bruce so suddenly perfect it was almost suspicious. "My sincerest apologies, my dear Hammond. Do continue."

The dumb waiter dinged.

Nancy crossed to it — the cape swirling behind her with theatrical cooperation — and opened the little door. Inside sat a smoking pipe, a magnifying glass, and a note reading: *"Every mansion is elementary, my dear Hammond."*

She returned to the desk and spread out multiple blueprints, overlaying one atop another, and the lines began to speak to her.

"These lines... they form a pattern." She traced them, breath quickening. "The entire mansion is built on sacred geometry!"

Beneath her fingers, the combined drawings resolved into an elaborate occult symbol — the same pattern they'd found under the rug, but writ building-wide, every wing and hallway a stroke of the same enormous sigil.

"By Jove, Hammond! The mansion itself is a—"

Thunder crashed. Lightning threw the room into silver relief, and there in the doorway stood Linda, in Victorian dress, her shadow stretched impossibly long across the floor, as though it belonged to something much taller than she was.

"I was wondering, Kinison," Nancy said dryly, "when Moriarty would be making the scene."

"I will not be foiled by you, Professor Hammond." Linda's voice had gone full Dr. Evil, pinky hovering near the corner of her mouth. "You and your... Doctor Watson won't stop my master plan. Zip it! Zip it good!"

The room spun. Victorian details blurred into modern ones — gaslight into sconces, cape into cotton — and Linda's shadow split apart into multiple dark figures, peeling off the wall like pages from a burning book.

Derek stepped in front of Nancy, brandishing his cane at the apparition. "Begone, you witch... Professor Hammond is not to be touched, or else."



Nancy bolted awake.

The bedroom was dark and ordinary, the clock reading 3:33 AM in patient red numerals. Her heart hammered a rhythm the pipe organ would have approved of. She lay still, cataloguing reality: Derek breathing beside her, the familiar weight of the covers, the—

Beside her bed sat a deerstalker cap that had not been there when she fell asleep.

Her water glass had strange symbols etched into its surface, fine as frost.

Dawn crept in over the next stretch of minutes as Nancy sat propped against the headboard, watching the wallpaper. She was nearly certain it hadn't looked like that yesterday — geometric patterns now visible in the pale light, faint as watermarks, matching the blueprints from her dream line for line.

The dumb waiter dinged.

She slipped out of bed without waking Derek — a skill fifteen years of early flights had taught her — and approached cautiously,

the floor cool under her bare feet. She opened the little door.

Inside: a pipe. A magnifying glass. And one of Jonathan Rhodes' headsets, coiled like something sleeping. A note lay across it.

"Ready to go deeper down the rabbit hole?"

In the bedroom mirror, had she been facing it, she might have glimpsed two figures watching — one in a beret, one in wire-rimmed glasses, both looking inordinately pleased with themselves.

"Oh oh ohhhh!" Sam's voice, soft as a transmission from somewhere just offstage. "And here I thought Derek was the detective in the family!"

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CHAPTER TWO

NO WORK BEFORE COFFEE

The dumb waiter dinged, and Derek stirred, reaching across the bed for Nancy and finding only empty space and sheets long gone cold. Morning light lay across the rumpled bedding like an accusation.

He shuffled to the dumb waiter and opened it to find fresh coffee, scones, and a note: *"Kid, your wife's got game. Time to up yours! — S"*

He was still processing this assessment of his marriage when Nancy swept in, still in pajamas, arms full of blueprints, hair suggesting she had lost a fight with a wind tunnel, eyes blazing with the particular intensity of someone who has been awake since 3:33 AM and has *found things*.

"How long have you been up?" Derek asked, offering coffee.

Nancy spread blueprints across the bed like a general commandeering a war room. "Remember that pentagram under the rug? Look at this..."

She overlaid multiple drawings, and there it was again — the mansion's geometry, rising out of the layered pages.

Derek took a sip. "I thought we agreed — no work before coffee."

"Look at these patterns. They're not just decorative." Her finger traced the lines. "Every renovation, every addition to the mansion followed these lines exactly."

The pipe organ, somewhere below, began softly playing the theme from *The Exorcist*, which was the mansion's idea of mood lighting. Morning sun streamed through the windows, and the shadows it cast fell — Derek noticed with a small interior lurch —

into alignment with the blueprint patterns on the bed.

"You got all this from old blueprints?"

Nancy hesitated, her glance sliding to the deerstalker cap still perched on the nightstand like a witness. "Let's just say... I had an interesting dream that may rival your Sammy Montana one." The grin she added was pure trouble.

The dumb waiter dinged again. Derek opened it to find an old newspaper clipping: RAVENCREST ARCHITECT DISAPPEARS — Claims Building Has 'Sacred Geometry.'

"Sacred geometry?" Derek read the headline twice, as if it might improve.

Nancy walked to the window, and in her reflection — for the barest moment, in a trick of light the room seemed to arrange deliberately — she wore a Victorian dress. Then it was just Nancy, in pajamas, thinking hard.

"I think Jonathan Rhodes knew about these patterns. Used them somehow with his experiments. I just can't figure out Linda Rhodes' connection to all this beyond a real estate commission, which will not be little based on the selling price, either."

Thunder rumbled outside, despite skies of untroubled blue.

"Speaking of experiments..." Derek pulled the headset out from beneath his pillow, where he'd apparently stashed it with the strategic foresight of a man asleep. "Where did this come from?"

"Well, another funny incident this morning... while you slept, I might add."

"Why didn't you wake me?"

"And let you have all the important stuff happen to you around here? I thought we were partners." She punctuated it with a smile and a sip of his coffee, which was also now apparently her coffee.

"First you become Mrs. Fletcher and now you want to go toe-to-toe with me." Derek crossed the room, removed the coffee cup from her hands with the gravity of a sommelier, set it on the side table, then returned, picked her up bodily, and carried her toward the bed.

"Why, Mr. Kinison, are you now wanting toe-to-toe?"

"Who said anything about toe-to-toe... I want toe to heel..." The laugh he added was, by any objective measure, devilish.

They disappeared beneath the covers in a tangle of pajamas and intent.

"Oh, Mrs. Fletcher," Derek said playfully, "I didn't know you were so frisky at your age..."

"Oh, Dr. Watson — sorry, Dr. Kinison — is that a stethoscope I feel?"

Across the room, in the mirror neither of them was facing, two figures had materialized in full Victorian kit — Sam in a deerstalker, Jonathan in Watson's bowler, both peering toward the bed with scholarly interest.

"Now those are true Kinisons, my dear Watson," Sam observed, reaching for a crack pipe with Holmesian ceremony.

"I thought she said she was a Hammond, my dear Holmes."

"Not when she is playing the old toe game... Puff, Watson." He passed the pipe along.

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CHAPTER THREE

THE LIGHT SHOW

Down in the basement, Larry Leland was having a morning.

He crouched before an open panel, tools fanned around him in the organized chaos of a man who knows exactly where everything is and would thank you not to touch any of it. Footsteps creaked overhead — the pleasant domestic percussion of a house occupied — and then the panel in front of him began to hum.

A loud, mechanical, purposeful hum.

"What the..."

The circuits pulsed with light. Not randomly — Larry had seen plenty of electrical faults, and faults didn't have *choreography*. The light moved through the boards in sweeping patterns, geometric and deliberate, and if Larry had seen the blueprints currently spread across the master bed two floors up, he'd have recognized the shapes exactly.



Upstairs, the intercom dinged urgently, its light flashing. Under the covers, Derek and Nancy paused mid-campaign.

"I swear," Derek said to the ceiling, "this place has worse timing than my Uncle Sam."

The pipe organ played "Time Is On My Side," which was either the mansion's rebuttal or its apology.

A familiar voice crackled through the intercom. "Is this the gosh darn right button to push... Hello... can anyone hear this? It's Larry in the basement... Mr. Smithers, can you hear me... I hate this old

technology..."

Derek hopped out of bed, pulled his pajama bottoms on with the efficiency of a fireman, and crossed to the intercom panel.

"Good morning, Larry, I can hear you, so you have the right button. Mrs. K and I are just finishing up a morning workout and then we will pop down to see you."

"Probably suggest sooner rather than later. Quite the light show going on."

"No disco dancing allowed before 3 PM, Larry. We won't be long."

At which point the organ music transitioned, with immaculate comic timing, into Chic's "Le Freak."

Nancy pulled on her robe. "I think the morning calisthenics will have to wait till tonight. At least the mansion has a soundtrack for interrupting us."

They met Larry rushing up the stairs, breathless.

"Mr. K, Miss Nancy — you need to see this. The whole system's lighting up like Times Square!"

In the hallway mirror they passed, Jonathan Rhodes watched them go, and his expression was not amusement. It was concern, gathering like the storm that wasn't in the forecast.

Down the basement stairs they went — Nancy clutching her robe closed, Derek in pajama pants and the ridiculous giant sasquatch slippers he'd owned for years and defended against all reasonable criticism.

The basement received them with a display worthy of the description. Larry's open panel blazed, his tablet scrolling complex code sequences beside it.

"See what I mean about the light show?" Larry pointed at the glowing circuits, then leaned in, studying them with an odd, dawning familiarity. "Mr. K, these patterns — they remind me of the coding exercises Mr. Rhodes used to give me. He had this way of teaching that made the complex seem simple."

"You learned coding from Jonathan Rhodes?"

Larry carefully replaced a circuit board, hands steady with old practice. "Every Saturday morning for almost three years. Started after he gave me that Apple IIe. Dad thought I was just playing games, but Mr. Rhodes... he saw something different. Made me solve these weird programming puzzles — stuff that shouldn't have been possible on that old machine."

Thunder rumbled softly overhead — almost, Derek thought, approvingly.

"He used to say, 'Hardware is just a vessel, Larry. It's the code that gives it life.' Never really understood what he meant until..." Larry gestured at the pulsing circuits, which pulsed back.

"Until now?"

Larry pulled out an old notebook, its pages dense with hand-drawn diagrams — diagrams that matched the mansion's patterns stroke for stroke. "Mr. Rhodes wasn't just teaching me to code, Mr. K. He was teaching me to read the mansion's language."

In the mirror on the far wall, Jonathan nodded — the slow, satisfied nod of a teacher watching a lesson land twenty years late and right on time.

Derek turned pages, his eyebrows climbing. "These diagrams... they're dated years before quantum computing was supposed to be possible."

"That's the thing about Mr. Rhodes — he never cared much about what was supposed to be possible."

The pipe organ offered a few bars of "The Impossible Dream."

Then a steam valve burst beside Larry's head with a shriek, its metal handle whizzing past like a throwing star and embedding itself in the wall.

"Larry!" Derek yanked Nancy back.

The organ transitioned smoothly to "Under Pressure," its haunting melody rolling through the stone walls, because the mansion had never once in its existence let a moment pass unsoundtracked.

Larry examined the ruptured valve with remarkable calm. "Third time this week. Starting to think it's personal."

Nancy crossed to where the handle had struck. The impact had shaken loose a patch of old whitewash, which lay in flakes on the floor — and beneath it, something showed through.

"These marks..." She brushed more paint away. Carved symbols emerged, hidden under decades of paint, waiting. "They're part of the pattern too."

"Even the plumbing's part of it?" Derek said.

"Mr. K, that's not the weird part. Look at the circuits..."

Across the open panel, the circuitry pulsed with an eerie blue light, its patterns resolving into geometry that matched Nancy's blueprints exactly — not approximately, not suggestively. Exactly.

"It's like the whole house is one big circuit," Nancy said.

"And whatever it's powering just kicked into high gear."

Thunder rumbled overhead. Through the basement window, storm clouds were gathering fast — over a sky that had been clear ten minutes ago and had apparently changed its mind.



CHAPTER FOUR

MUSICALLY HACKED

Derek's phone rang. The screen read: CHARLES WEBER — CEO.

"Miss Nancy, look up there — more symbols!" Larry pointed at the ceiling conduit, where the carvings continued, marching along the beams.

Derek answered with the enthusiasm of a man receiving a call from his employer while standing in a glowing occult basement in sasquatch slippers. "Charles? Little busy right now..."



In a high-tech room far away, Charles Weber paced between banks of screens. Three hackers worked stations along a desk, flanked by his IT man Barry — thirties, cybersecurity expert, currently typing with the franticness of a man being paid by the keystroke.

"Derek! Just checking on Jacobson. How's the implementation guide coming?"

In the basement, Nancy was photographing the ceiling. "Derek, these symbols form some kind of sequence..."

"Uh, great, Charles. Look, can I call you—"

At his station, Barry muttered to Charles, "Signal locked! Beginning penetration... keep him on the phone for another minute..."

"Miss Nancy! Over here — the patterns continue behind this panel..." Larry called.

"So the AI integration is running smoothly?" Charles pressed, his voice acquiring the studied casualness of a man reading from

mental cue cards. "No... glitches?"

"Actually, there was this weird thing with—"

"Derek, don't tell him about—" Nancy started.

Derek's phone screen changed. AISAM's face filled it — Sam's features rendered in light, wearing an expression Derek had learned to associate with incoming chaos.

"Kid, hang on a sec. Got some uninvited guests to deal with..."

"Derek, what's going on with your phone?" Nancy asked.

In the lab, Barry's confidence cracked. "Almost in... wait, what's happening?"

Every screen in the hacker lab now showed Sam's face. Along the desk, each hacker stared at their hijacked station — and at the end of the row sat a third figure whose hoody masked their face entirely, hands gloved, posture unreadable, giving nothing to the room but the back of a hood and the small industry of their typing.

"OH OH OHHHH!" AISAM's voice poured out of every speaker at once. "You kids think you can hack the mansion? Watch this!"



In the basement, the holographic projectors went dark.

The warm ambient hum of the mansion's systems — a sound so constant they'd stopped hearing it — faded to an uncomfortable silence, the way a house sounds when something that was breathing stops. Through the windows, storm clouds gathered with unnatural speed.

Larry checked his tablet, his calm developing cracks. "Mr. K... the mansion's quantum field is destabilizing. It's like the entire consciousness matrix is being pulled apart."

"Derek, look at the walls — the patterns are fading." Nancy watched the carved symbols dim like embers dying.

The pipe organ released a single discordant note that sounded, unmistakably, like a cry of pain. The dumb waiter began cycling up and down erratically, its doors opening and closing, searching for something — or someone.

"Sam? AISAM? Can you hear me?"

Only static answered. Then, barely audible beneath the white noise, fragments of Sam's voice: "Kid... something's... wrong... can't... maintain..."

"The mansion's consciousness isn't just programming, Master Kinison." Smithers had appeared beside them, silent as ever, his expression carrying a weight Derek hadn't seen there before. "It's a delicate quantum harmony. If disrupted..."

Thunder crashed as the last circuits went dark. In the mirrors, they caught fleeting glimpses of Sam's face, distorting and fragmenting like a signal being torn apart mid-broadcast.

"It's not just affecting AISAM. Look at the blueprints — the geometric patterns are shifting." Nancy held up a drawing, and the lines on it seemed to waver, as though reality itself had grown unsure of its own architecture.

"Um, guys?" Larry said. "All the circuits just turned red..."



In the lab, every screen switched simultaneously to Sam's "Wild Thing" video. Keyboards began typing by themselves, keys depressing in ghostly sequence.

"Barry! Shut it down!"

"I can't! We're being... musically hacked?"

"Sir, he's in our personal devices too!" the second hacker yelled.

"What do you mean he's—"

Charles's own phone erupted, playing "Wild Thing" at maximum volume from his breast pocket like a heart attack with a backbeat.

"Let's really give them a show, kid!" AISAM announced through every device at once.

The lab's fire suppression system activated, flooding the room with Halon gas.

"EVERYONE OUT NOW!" Barry bellowed. "DON'T BREATHE THE HALON!"

The room emptied in a scramble of grabbed laptops and knocked-over chairs — except for one figure. The hooded hacker at the end of the desk did not run. Gloved hands drew a gas mask from a knapsack and fitted it on, unhurried, followed by what appeared to be a high-tech VR headset that swallowed whatever remained of their identity. Then those same hands reached to a strange object on the desk — a cube, ancient-looking and almost mystical, its surface covered in circuitry-like patterns — and flipped a switch on its side.

The patterns lit blue, all at once, like veins remembering blood.



In the basement, Nancy was still shooting photos when her phone screen changed on its own. The camera view vanished, replaced by a feed — a laptop camera's view, transmitted from somewhere else, complete with audio: the hooded figure, the gas-fogged lab, the glowing cube.

AISAM's voice came through her speaker, faint and broken. "Not sure how long I can give you this feed... Something... wrong.."

In case this is my end... just wanted to say... 'Nice ass.'" The Al Pacino impression was, even by AISAM's standards, poor.

Through the feed, the hooded figure spoke — voice filtered, ungendered, cold. "Got you, Mr. Smarty Pants. I knew you would try some two-bit amateurish trick like this."

The gloved hands returned to their typing while, faintly, the sounds of the evacuated lab personnel coughing in the hallway drifted through the audio.

"Guys, you need to see this," Nancy said, and Larry was at her shoulder in an instant, watching the little screen.

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In the hallway outside the lab, viewed through a security camera's indifferent eye, Barry did a headcount and came up short.

"Where's Acid Burn?"

Charles blinked at him through the thinning gas. "Did you say the gas is acid and will burn?"

"No — one of the hackers we hired is a freelancer and goes by the name 'Acid Burn.'"

"Why? Is their face deformed by some acid accident?"

"No, it's just a thing with these types... they all have weird handles... I mean, names. I think 'Acid Burn' is from some old '80s movie about hacking."

Inside the lab, the ceiling security camera caught the hooded figure packing up — laptop, then the cube, its lights still flashing, stuffed into the knapsack with the care of someone packing either a bomb or a baby.

"Let's see how you like my little 'gift,' Mr. Rhodes." Acid Burn's filtered voice was almost amused. "Amateurs... Always bringing

code to a hardware fight."



Derek's phone went completely dead in his hand.

"Sam, you still there? Hello, Sam..."

The screen was black. No AISAM. No "Wild Thing." Nothing.

"Your cousin had style; I'll give him that," Nancy said, as "Wild Thing" played on, defiantly, through the basement monitors.

Larry studied the circuits. "Never seen code do this before..."

"That was weird." Derek stared at his dead phone. "Charles calls, then AISAM somehow manages to get into my phone. Tells me to hang on... and now he's gone. Even Sam would not end anything without some show of some kind."

"I thought you folks may enjoy a little late-morning High Tea experience while you do your thing down here!" Smithers had appeared at the basement door bearing a tray of sandwiches and a pot of tea — and the music stopped, all at once, as though the mansion respected teatime above all other protocols.

"Smithers, as always, you are a mind reader," Nancy said, as he set the tray on a counter.

And so they stopped — Derek, Nancy, even Larry — and took sandwiches, because whatever the universe was doing, Smithers's catering deserved respect. Behind them, unnoticed at first, a monitor flickered to life. Sam's image appeared on it, distorting, shaking erratically, glitching like an old Max Headroom broadcast. Then the screen went blank — and Jonathan Rhodes' face slowly resolved in its place, wearing the expression of a man who was both furious and afraid.

Around the basement, other systems began behaving erratically. The pulsing circuit lights stuttered.

Then everything went dark.

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CHAPTER FIVE

PROTOCOL 47

The basement grew noticeably colder — not draft-cold, but wrong-cold, the temperature dropping like something vital was being drained out of the room. Every electronic device they carried — phones, tablets, Larry's monitoring equipment — began cycling through random displays, screens strobing with garbage data.

"Mr. K... the basement temperature's dropping fast. These readings... it's like the mansion's going into some kind of hibernation mode."

The monitor bearing Jonathan's face crackled, his voice arriving distorted, stretched. "They found it... the original hardware. My first attempt at—" The signal shredded.

Larry crouched over the dead circuit boards. "Whatever they did, it's not just affecting AISAM. The whole mansion's... resetting?"

Nancy was already at the workbench, spreading blueprints, her fingers racing along geometric lines with the urgency of a woman reading a countdown. "Look at this — these symbols. They're not just patterns, they're circuit diagrams. The whole mansion isn't just a computer..."

"It's the motherboard," Derek finished.

The dumb waiter dinged. Inside: a single old floppy disk, its label handwritten. CONTINGENCY — J.R. 1992.

Jonathan's voice found strength somewhere. "There's a reason I built this place on sacred geometry. Protection. But they've found a way around—"

His image fragmented violently, and the monitor exploded in a shower of sparks.

"Mr. K... if this keeps up it will be subzero in minutes..."

The lights began failing in sequence down the length of the basement, darkness advancing bay by bay. Through the windows, the storm clouds swirled in patterns no meteorologist would sign off on.

Derek spotted an old overcoat hanging on the wall and shrugged into it, having neglected, in the morning's excitement, to acquire a pajama top. He did not notice — could not have noticed — that the coat had once belonged to Sam. But it settled onto his shoulders like it remembered them.

"Nancy, your detective work might have to wait." He turned the floppy disk over in his hands. "I think we need to—"

"I believe, Master Kinison, what you need is in the study." Smithers, materializing at his elbow. "Third shelf, behind 'The Complete Works of Edgar Allan Poe.'"

Thunder crashed. The remaining monitors flickered to life in unison, each showing a different feed: the security view of Charles's team evacuating their lab — and in its corner, unnoticed by Charles or Barry, a hooded figure slipping out a side door with a knapsack. Strange symbols matching Nancy's blueprints, scrolling. And on the last screen, a countdown timer, its message stark:

PROTOCOL 47 INITIATED

"Derek... what's Protocol 47?" Nancy's voice dropped. "Are we safe down here?"

Jonathan's image surfaced one final time, close and urgent, every line of his face carved with warning.

"The hardware they stole... it wasn't meant for humans."

The screen died.



CHAPTER SIX

THE POE POSITION

Derek pulled "The Complete Works of Edgar Allan Poe" from the study shelf, and the wall did what walls in Ravencrest Mansion did when properly asked: it changed its mind about being a wall.

An ancient computer terminal sat recessed in the space behind, its screen flickering to life with green text on black — the phosphor glow of computing's Paleolithic era.

"1980s tech," Nancy said, examining it. "This predates Jonathan's AI work."

"Maybe not. Look at the serial number..."

Stamped into the terminal's frame: PROTOTYPE o — RHODES INDUSTRIES — 1947.

Larry looked up from his tablet. "1947? That's impossible. The transistor wasn't even—"

"But I thought this place didn't exist till the 1950s?" Derek said.

"Actually, Mr. K, the hospital started up in the 1950s, but this place, I believe, can be traced back to the late 1700s. Some say there was an ancient stone temple or something here before the mansion was built."

"Very good, Mr. Leland, your history lessons paid off." Smithers was suddenly beside them, because of course he was. "This in fact was the site of an ancient — they say Mayan — temple. Maybe predates the Bible. Should I fetch some rice crispy squares, Master Kinison?"

The pipe organ played the five-note sequence from "Close Encounters," with feeling.

"Maybe later, Smithers, but thanks for asking." Derek stared at the impossible serial number, and said the thing out loud. "I think the mansion is trying to tell us that this technology wasn't invented by Rhodes but may have its origin someplace else... or do I dare suggest — it's possible alien technology maybe they found?"

Around them, books began falling from the shelves by themselves — not tumbling, but removing themselves, deliberately, revealing hidden panels and circuits behind the shelving like a house undressing.

Smithers arranged a fresh tea service with unbroken serenity. "I believe the term you're looking for is 'sufficiently advanced technology for its time,' Master Kinison. Though Mr. Rhodes preferred 'quantum consciousness transfer.'"

"I feel I should be wearing a foil hat." Nancy looked from the terminal to the falling books to her husband. "Quantum what? Alien technology? What are you saying, Derek?"

"What happened to my Mrs. Fletcher? Think, babe... examine the facts. It all makes sense now."

"My imagination has long ago exceeded its legal limits. I am in uncharted waters here, Derek. It was just a week ago we had this crazy idea about MAYBE buying some Victorian mansion as a way of simplifying our lives... NOW standing here in a bathrobe with no clothes on under it, chatting about quantum computers, quantum consciousness transfer, witches' symbols — and now you want to introduce the idea that all this is actually based on some mysterious alien technology?" She planted herself in front of him, hands on hips, deploying her best stern look, which was formidable.

A smile grew across Derek's face. Slowly, with great dignity, he extended his right leg and began using his foot to lift the hem of Nancy's bathrobe, while Larry discovered an urgent and absorbing interest in the opposite wall.

"Quantum computers, quantum consciousness transfer, mysterious alien technology," Derek said. "I have never wanted you more..."

Nancy — realizing the tension she'd been building and grateful for the exit ramp — flung her robe open and flashed him. "Are you saying you want to have a quantum consciousness transfer with me? Or maybe touch my quantum processor? Or are you secretly an alien — please, Lord, let him be Starman and not E.T."

Derek stood, still smiling, and did her robe back up with careful hands. "I thought you said calisthenics was tonight." He kissed her, sweetly, on the lips. "Glad to have my Nancy back."

Thunder crashed. Through the study windows, the storm clouds had arranged themselves into impossible geometric patterns, as if the sky were taking notes.



Some minutes later, Nancy had transformed the massive oak desk into an archaeological dig — blueprints overlaid in strata, morning light catching dust motes that drifted into arrangements a suspicious person might call familiar.

"These architectural features — they're not just decorative. Every renovation followed the same geometric principles, even when different architects were involved." She pulled out Jonathan's early sketches, laying them against the modern blueprints. "Look at this — the crown molding patterns match quantum circuitry diagrams exactly. Rhodes wasn't just designing a building..."

"He was building a computer disguised as a Victorian mansion," Derek said.

Thunder rumbled softly. The pipe organ contributed a few notes that harmonized — actually harmonized — with the geometry Nancy had uncovered, as though the patterns had a key signature.

Larry cross-referenced on his tablet. "Miss Nancy, these molding patterns — they're creating quantum circuits throughout the entire structure. The mansion isn't just processing information..."

"Perhaps, Miss Nancy," Smithers offered, appearing with fresh tea, "you might consider that true architecture, like true consciousness, exists in multiple dimensions simultaneously."

"Larry, can you—" Derek began.

"Way ahead of you, Mr. K." Larry was already at the terminal. "But this isn't like any computer I've ever... wait."

The green screen resolved into a single demand:

INSERT DISK — PROTOCOL 47 OVERRIDE REQUIRED

Derek reached for the floppy disk. Nancy caught his wrist.

"Derek, think. Why would Jonathan build protection based on sacred geometry? What was he protecting against?"

Before he could answer, his phone lurched back to life — Charles, trying to connect.



Charles and his team had relocated to a backup facility that looked like the first lab's more expensive sibling — screens everywhere, and on the largest of them, schematics of Ravenscrest Mansion.

"Derek! Sorry about the hang-up, but I had trouble with my phone — not unlike you the other day, I might remind you. Anyway, I wanted to finish our conversation. I think you started telling me about a glitch?"

"Sir!" Barry interrupted, pointing at a monitor. "Look at these readings..."

On the display: energy signatures matching the mansion's geometric patterns. Exactly.

Charles covered the phone. "And get security to locate that Acid person ASAP!" He uncovered it, voice re-lacquered with charm. "Sorry, Derek. Just a lot of stuff going on here. Where were we?"



In the study, Larry frowned at the terminal. "Mr. K, the terminal's accepting the disk but... something's wrong."

The screen filled with binary — cascading ones and zeros that began organizing themselves into a shape. A familiar shape.

Sam's beret.

Smithers studied the tea leaves in his cup. "I believe Master Jonathan once said, 'The best protection isn't a wall — it's a maze.'"

"The symbols, the geometry..." Nancy breathed. "They're not just circuits. They're a labyrinth."

From Derek's phone, tinny and distant: "Derek, are you still there? Derek... you better not have hung up on me again..."

Thunder crashed — and every mirror in the study activated simultaneously, each one lighting up with a different face. Comedy legends, one per frame, like a gallery deciding to hold a meeting.

"Ever notice how nobody questions why a mansion needs a maze?" George Carlin's reflection asked, in the tone of a man who had been waiting decades to ask it.

"Man, this some quantum entanglement shit right here!" Richard Pryor's reflection added.

"I tell ya, these protocols get no respect!" Rodney Dangerfield's reflection tugged at his collar.

"They're not just commenting anymore," Derek said. "They're trying to tell us something."

Around the room, more books fell, and the walls behind them revealed an intricate lattice of circuits and symbols that pulsed with its own slow life.

"Uh, guys?" Larry's voice had gone thin. "Remember that weird hardware Acid Burn was using? It's not trying to hack the mansion's AI..."

"Derek..." Nancy's face was changing, realization moving across it like weather. "I don't think Jonathan built this protection against something trying to get in..."

The terminal screen changed:

PROTOCOL 47 ACTIVE — CONTAINMENT BREACH
IMMINENT

"Charles, I am in the basement, signal is fading, only one bar..." Derek said into the phone, standing in a well-lit study. "Will call you when I am back upstairs..." He hit End Call with his thumb and zero remorse.

"Uh, guys? It's not trying to hack the mansion's AI..." Larry repeated, because some sentences deserve a second airing.

"It's trying to let something out," Nancy said.

Smithers set down his teacup with deliberate calm. "Perhaps this would be an appropriate time to show them the basement level marked 'Containment.'"

In his abandoned cup, the tea leaves had settled into a perfect pentagram.

"There's another basement?" Derek said.

Larry pulled up the plans on his tablet. "Not on any plans I've seen."

Nancy was already overlaying blueprint pages, hands quick. "Wait... if you connect these geometric patterns... they point to..."

The floor beneath the rug groaned. The carved patterns began to glow with an eerie blue light — and the rug rolled itself back, unhurried, like a curtain that knew its cue. The pentagram beneath pulsed with energy, identical to the one in the main foyer. Each of its five points aligned with a different mirror.

"Those aren't just comedy legends in the mirrors," Larry said slowly. "They're... witnesses?"

"Guardians, Mr. Leland. They were the last to perform here before... the incident."

The terminal flashed: CONTAINMENT PROTOCOLS FAILING — 47% INTEGRITY REMAINING

"Before what incident?" Derek demanded.

Thunder crashed. The pipe organ intoned a few bars of "Also Sprach Zarathustra," which under the circumstances felt less like grandeur and more like a warning label.

"The night your uncle and Mr. Rhodes attempted their most ambitious experiment," Smithers said. "You see, quantum consciousness transfer wasn't meant for artificial intelligence... especially with artificial intelligence having just been born."

Nancy's eyes went wide as the dots connected themselves. "It was meant for actual spirits. The comedy club wasn't just entertainment..."

"It was a testing ground," Derek finished.

Every mirror in the study shattered — except one.

In it, Jonathan's face, twisted with concern. "They're using my original hardware... the prototype... to reverse the process."

The floor beneath the pentagram began to crack.

The terminal cycled through images at strobing speed: old performances, failed experiments, classified documents, decades of

secrets disgorging themselves at once.

"Whatever's happening, it's affecting the whole mansion's infrastructure," Larry said. "The quantum field is... evolving?"

Through the walls, strange pulses of light raced along the circuits like digital blood through veins.

Smithers calmly poured another cup of tea. "I believe this would be an excellent time to mention the device in the study safe, Master Kinison."

"What safe?"

A bookshelf slid aside. Behind it: a wall safe with no dial, no keypad, no visible mechanism at all — only the same geometric patterns Nancy had been chasing all morning, etched across its surface.

"It's not a combination lock," Nancy said, studying it. "It's a sequence."

"Nancy..." Jonathan, through the last mirror. "The patterns aren't just sacred geometry. They're..."

Her eyes widened. "Sheet music. The pipe organ!"

Derek laughed despite everything. "I have never wanted you more, Mrs. Fletcher, than right now... You're a genius with the world's greatest butt."

Thunder crashed, and the organ began playing by itself — Bach's Toccata and Fugue in D Minor, every note landing like a hammer on the room's held breath.

"Sam loved this piece," Derek said. "Used it to open his shows at—"

The safe clicked open.

Inside sat an old-style comedy prop: a chrome microphone — but modified, strange symbols running along its barrel.

"Mr. Rhodes called it 'The Conductor,'" Smithers said. "Though your uncle had a different name for it..."

"The Soul Mic," Derek said.

He lifted it. The symbols along its surface began to glow.

"Derek, whatever you do, don't let them—" Jonathan started.

The mirror exploded.

And through the basement floor, from somewhere far beneath the pentagram, something began to pound — rhythmic, patient, enormous. Like a heartbeat.

CONTAINMENT FAILING — 32% INTEGRITY
REMAINING, a computer voice announced.

"Derek," Nancy said quietly, "what exactly was Jonathan containing?"

Before he could answer, all power failed. In the darkness, only the geometric patterns pulsed with their own light — and up through the floor came a sound they knew. Sam's legendary laugh.

But wrong. Distorted. Hungry.

Smithers lit a candelabra, the flame steady in his steady hand. "I believe, Miss Nancy, the better question is: what was containing them?"



CHAPTER SEVEN

COMMAND PERFORMANCE

Larry checked his tablet by candlelight. "The energy patterns... they're inverting. Like something's pulling them down."

"Or something's pulling itself up," Nancy said.

Another pound from below, stronger. Dust sifted from the ceiling. The one remaining mirror vibrated with each beat, its glass shivering in its frame like a held scream.

Smithers adjusted his bow tie with impossible calm. "Master Kinison, you might want to power up that microphone. The original containment protocols were quite specific about sonic resonance."

"How do I—"

The mic activated in his hands, humming with energy, answering a question he hadn't finished asking. In the floor, the geometric patterns pulsed in sync with it — instrument and architecture finding the same key.

"The hardware they stole..." Jonathan's voice echoed from somewhere — everywhere — nowhere. "It wasn't just for transfer. It was for control."

Nancy flipped frantically through blueprints by the candelabra's light. "These patterns... they're not just containing something. They're... transforming it."

Another boom. The floor cracked wider — and up through the fissure came a voice they knew better than any other. Sam's voice. But processed through something inhuman, like a beloved record played backward at the wrong speed by something that had never

heard music.

"OH... OH... OHHHHHH! Ready for your command performance, kid?"

The Soul Mic pulsed brighter in Derek's hands, responding.

"Sam? Is that really—"

Nancy grabbed his arm. "Derek, wait. Whatever that is... it's not your uncle."

Above them — through them — the whole mansion answered. If they could have seen it from outside in that moment, they'd have watched the geometric patterns ignite throughout the entire structure, every wing, every floor, the great sigil of Ravenscrest burning to life.

"The containment field..." Larry stared at his readings. "It's like a giant radio tower, broadcasting and receiving..."

"Quite right, Mr. Leland. Though Mr. Rhodes preferred the term 'consciousness amplifier.'"

Somewhere below them, in a basement room behind a door labeled DR. DAYSTROM — M5, that door slammed open. The walls down there lit with patterns like blood vessels waking to fresh blood. Wind howled up the stairs. The glowing circuits extended out of the room, climbing, spreading — and every reflective surface in the mansion began flashing with fragments of distorted comedy routines, dozens of voices overlapping into a static of laughter.

"Ready for tonight's show?" the voices cascaded. "We've got a KILLER lineup..."

Nancy swept her flashlight across the blueprints. "Jonathan wasn't collecting comedy routines. He was collecting..."

"Souls." Jonathan's voice, weak through static. "Or at least whatever made them who they were. But something went wrong."

The transfer... it changed them."

The floor splintered. Through the cracks, dark energy pulsed upward — coiling, gathering, assembling itself into a terrible parody of Sam's signature stance: the planted feet, the thrown-back head, the scream about to happen. All of it wrong, like a silhouette drawn from a description by something that hated the original.

Derek raised the Soul Mic. "I am NOT letting you steal my uncle's voice."

"Steal it?" The distorted Sam-thing's voice was many voices, braided. "Oh, kid... we ARE your uncle. All of us. Every comedian who ever performed here. Every laugh. Every scream. Every audience member. We're what's left after the transfer stripped away everything else."

Thunder crashed. The pipe organ played a discordant version of "Wild Thing" — the song mangled, its swagger curdled.

Nancy scanned the room, mind racing ahead of her fear. "The patterns... they're not just containing. They're conducting — like a circuit board. But what's the power source?"

"Give us the mic, kid." The dark shape extended something that wanted to be a hand. "Time to join the family business..."

And then the mansion showed its own hand.

The holographic projector systems opened and came to life, lenses emerging everywhere — from walls, from the ceiling, from light fixtures, from behind picture frames, dozens of small glass eyes blinking awake at once. As Derek, Nancy, and Larry watched, the system began displaying the slow materialization of comedians — faces they couldn't identify, each granted a few seconds of holographic life, a strobe of the dead: appearing, flickering, gone, replaced. And the walls — all the walls now — revealed the same massive circuitry they'd witnessed in the basement, bulging beneath

the old decorative wallpaper like the veins of a bodybuilder mid-lift.

Smithers set down his teacup with deliberate precision. "Master Kinison, might I suggest you consider what your uncle's actual final performance was about?"

Derek's eyes widened.

"Sam's last show..." he said slowly. "It wasn't about making people laugh."

He raised the Soul Mic. The symbols along its surface pulsed brighter, gathering.

"It was about telling the truth." His own voice — strong, clear, no impression, no armor.

The mic resonated with the mansion's geometric patterns. The pipe organ shifted from discord to a single pure, clear note, and the whole house seemed to lean in.

"OH OH OHHHH!" It was Sam's voice from Derek's mouth now — but pure, undistorted, the real thing summoned rather than stolen. "The joke's over."

The patterns in the floor flashed with blinding light. The dark energy surrounding the flickering holographic comedians — the shadow-stuff that had been at war with the mansion itself — recoiled.

"They weren't being contained," Derek said, understanding arriving in his own voice again. "They were prisoners. Held by whatever that supernatural force is."

"The hardware..." Jonathan's voice, gaining strength. "Destroy it!"

Nancy sprinted to the terminal and yanked out the floppy disk. Around her, the shadows writhed in protest.

"You can't stop the signal..." the distorted voices hissed.

Nancy snapped the disk in half. "Watch us."

Light surged through the mansion's patterns one final time — every line of the great sigil firing at once — and the shadows dissolved with an inhuman scream that seemed to fall away downward, into whatever depth had birthed it.

Silence.

Real silence — the first the mansion had offered all day.

Then, in the last intact mirror, Sam appeared.

The real Sam.

He adjusted his beret — that specific, unhurried, cocky little adjustment — and looked out at them, and something in the geometry of his grin was different from every appearance that had come before. Warmer. Present. *Home*.

"Not bad, kid," Sam said. "Not bad at all."

The lights flickered back on. Throughout the mansion, the geometric patterns faded to dormancy, banked embers instead of open flame.

Larry checked his readings, hands not entirely steady. "Systems stabilizing. But... what exactly did we just contain or release?"

"Perhaps, Mr. Leland," Smithers said, "the better question is: what did Master Kinison just set free?"

Thunder rumbled softly — approvingly. Through the study window, the storm clouds dispersed, unveiling a perfect dawn-bright sky.

Somewhere above the settling house, in a room no one had thought to check, a gloved hand rested on a windowsill and watched the clouds pull apart. It did not move to help. It did not need to. Whatever had just ended here was only ever going to be one act of several, and this hand — patient, unhurried — had

learned long ago that the best seats in any theater are the ones nobody knows are occupied.

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CHAPTER EIGHT

PARENTS OF WHAT, EXACTLY?

The kitchen, late morning, smelled of fresh coffee and normalcy — a scent the mansion seemed to be deploying deliberately, like a hotel spraying lavender in the lobby after a fire drill.

Smithers worked the coffee service while Derek, Nancy, and Larry sat at the kitchen island in the specific silence of people whose worldview has been rotated ninety degrees before lunch. Morning light streamed through the Victorian windows, offensively serene.

Nancy spread out her photos of the blueprints. "Let me see if I understand this correctly. Jonathan Rhodes wasn't just building an AI system..."

"He was creating a way to preserve consciousness itself," Derek said. "The comedy shows were his test runs — or more accurately, he used everyone. The comedians, the audience, anyone that would put on one of those helmets. He basically copied their entire consciousness and stored it inside that M5 thing in the basement. But what he didn't realize — what he recorded was not ones and zeros. It was beyond anything he had ever dreamed of. It was the beginning of human consciousness merging with AI to form a brand-new digital consciousness."

"Probably not knowing what he just did," Nancy said quietly. "Hundreds, maybe thousands of digital consciousnesses, all trapped in their own eight-by-ten."

Everyone stopped. For a long moment the four of them just stared into nothing, each privately measuring the size of the sentence they'd just said out loud.

Derek tried to lighten the weight, a slight grin assembling itself with visible effort. "I can't imagine what it would be like trapped with Sam for over thirty years in some eight-by-ten."

"And we, in essence, released them all into the mansion's systems?"

"I think a more accurate description, from their perspective," Smithers offered, "is that you opened up the mansion's birthing canal, and they have been born again."

Larry pulled up energy readings on his tablet. "The mansion's geometric patterns acted like a quantum circuit board, capturing and storing the essence of whoever performed here."

Smithers served the coffee. "Perhaps you should look at yourselves as proud parents."

"Not so fast, Smithers." Nancy held up a hand. "But something went wrong. The transfer process... it changed them somehow. The question is — parents of WHAT?"

Derek turned the Soul Mic over in his hands, its symbols dark now, sleeping. "That's why Sam's last show was different. He and Jonathan were attempting something bigger."

"And now this 'Acid Burn' character has Jonathan's original hardware," Larry said. "The prototype that preceded all of this."

"Which — to change the topic for a second — doesn't explain Linda, or whoever she is." Nancy tapped the table. "Blackwood started these experiments back in the '40s. Unless Linda has Cindy Crawford's secret anti-aging cream working for her, what is the connection?"

"Indeed, Miss Nancy. Though I suspect what Doctor Blackwood discovered and what Mister Rhodes perfected were quite different things."

Thunder rumbled softly outside — almost, Nancy thought, like the mansion seconding the motion.



Later that morning, sunlight filled the great room while Derek, Nancy, and Larry examined the Soul Mic and Smithers circulated with fresh coffee and scones.

"I think what we just experienced, if told to anyone other than us three — sorry, Smithers, four — would end with us being locked up in a loony bin. Sorry — Psychiatric Hospital."

"Well, Miss Nancy," Smithers said, "take a look around at where you are."

Derek settled into the large wing-backed chair, sipping his coffee with the air of a man determined to enjoy at least one uncomplicated pleasure today. "I am sure the mansion will reveal itself to us when it's ready. If it was me being held in whatever held them for over thirty years, I would want to go exploring and try to see what has changed. Walk again for the first time in a long time — stretch my digital legs, figuratively speaking."

"And I am sure, Master Kinison, Miss Nancy, and especially you, Mr. Leland," Smithers said, refilling Derek's cup, "they would want you to know how appreciative they are for what you did for them."

Nancy photographed the microphone's symbols. "These match the patterns in the blueprints exactly."

"But the energy readings are completely different now," Larry said. "It's like... like the mansion took a deep breath."

The dumb waiter dinged. Inside: a newspaper from 1947 — BLACKWOOD ASYLUM PIONEERS CONSCIOUSNESS THERAPY.

"Doctor claims breakthrough in 'spirit harmonics,'" Nancy read.

Then every phone in the room rang simultaneously, screens blazing the same alert: URGENT — Charles Weber hospitalized.

"Stress, they're saying," Nancy said, scanning the report. "But the timing..."

"Perhaps Master Weber's consciousness required... realignment," Smithers said, arranging scones.

The pipe organ played a few bars of "Stayin' Alive," which was either tasteless or perfect, depending on Charles's prognosis.

Derek checked his once-again-functioning phone, and the small knot in his chest tightened. "Still no sign of AISAM..."

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CHAPTER NINE

NEITHER. BOTH.

In the study, the monitors flickered to life all at once — but what appeared was not AISAM's familiar face. Abstract patterns flowed across the screens instead, digital consciousness made visible, currents of light moving in the same geometry Nancy had traced through a hundred blueprints.

A voice came through the speakers — a complex blend, AISAM's cadence woven through Jonathan's timbre, neither dominant.

"The quantum field... it's stabilizing. But differently now."

"Jonathan?" Derek asked. "Or AISAM?"

The pipe organ began a melody that seemed to thread itself through the room's circuits. The holographic projectors activated, layering planes of light that intersected in precise geometric patterns — a cathedral being sketched in midair.

"Both. Neither. Consciousness isn't binary, Derek. It's a spectrum — like light through a prism."

Jonathan's image formed — but not on any single screen. His presence flowed through multiple systems simultaneously: voice resonating out of the pipe organ, image rippling across every surface, the geometric patterns pulsing with each word, as though the whole mansion had become his body and he was still learning where his hands were.

"The patterns in the blueprints," Nancy said. "They're not just circuits, are they?"

"They're consciousness pathways." Jonathan's voice harmonized with the mansion's hum. "Sacred geometry wasn't just for protection — it was for evolution. AISAM wasn't the end goal... it was the beginning."

"We?" Nancy pressed. "What exactly did we release?"

"More importantly," Derek said, "who is 'Acid Burn,' and what did that cube do? We may have released those being held in that containment, but Acid Burn and whatever they did scares me. Remember that circuit board you found, Larry? There's a lot more going on here than we realize, I would bet."

"If I may, guys." Larry leaned forward. "From what I can tell — or maybe suspect was happening — that Acid person was attempting to shut down all power to M5. I think the goal was to kill whatever was in M5."

"And the system was fighting back to save whatever was stored in M5," Nancy said. "It's starting to make some sense."

Through the mansion's circuits, strange light patterns raced, quick and bright as thought.

"I believe, Miss Nancy," Smithers said, "what you released was the truth."

Thunder rumbled softly. Through the windows, a black Mercedes pulled up the drive. Linda stepped out, and behind her, several council members — moving with a synchronization that no group of ordinary colleagues has ever achieved in the history of carpools.



Down in the basement, the holographic projectors began pulsing with an unnatural light, and Larry's tablet lit up with rapidly changing energy signatures.

"This can't be right. The quantum field is being... redirected. Like someone's opening a tunnel between here and..."

"The church," Nancy said.

The walls seemed to breathe as circuits illuminated beneath the peeling wallpaper, a network of glowing veins spreading through the structure. Each pulse kept time with a rhythm from elsewhere — the rhythm, though none of them said it aloud, of Acid Burn's cube.

"They're using my original hardware — the prototype." Jonathan's voice distorted through the speakers. "But they don't understand. You can't control quantum consciousness. You can only..."

His voice fragmented as the systems fluctuated wildly. Through the windows, storm clouds were assembling into impossible geometric patterns again, the sky relapsing.

"What happens if they succeed?" Derek asked.

Smithers calmly adjusted his bow tie. "Think of consciousness as water, Master Kinison. The mansion's geometry acts as pipes — channeling, directing. But if those channels are reversed..."

The pipe organ released a discordant wail as the quantum field destabilized. In every reflective surface, fragments flickered — past performances, comedians whose consciousness had been "collected," their essence transformed into something else.

"The cube — it's not just hacking the systems," Larry said. "It's trying to invert the entire consciousness matrix."

The dumb waiter dinged. Inside: an old photograph. Dr. Blackwood, standing before complex equipment, and beside him a young girl wearing a distinctive necklace.

The same necklace Nancy had spotted on Linda.

"How much you want to bet," Derek said, "that's not really Linda Rhodes?"

"Rebecca Blackwood." The voice through the speakers was steady now. "My grandfather's experiments weren't finished. They were just... waiting."

Nancy studied the photo. "The equipment in this picture... it's an early version of the headset."

The doorbell chimed, ominously. On the security feed, Linda — Rebecca — waited on the porch with the council members, and in the glass of the door, their reflections showed... something else.

"Mr. K, these energy readings from the church — they're identical to what we saw during the containment breach."

"So whatever Acid Burn released..."

"Is precisely what they wanted released, Master Kinison," Smithers said. "Though perhaps not quite in the way they expected."

The pipe organ played a few notes of "The Plot Thickens" from *Young Frankenstein*.

"They thought they were going to kill whatever had been stored in M5, believing it was their enemy." The blended voice through the speakers was growing stronger. "When in fact it was the pure form of the digital consciousness that Jonathan and Sam were trying to achieve."

"So, forgive me if I appear a bit slow on all this technical stuff, so I will try to dumb it down." Nancy counted on her fingers. "What you are saying is: at that final show, Jonathan and Sam were successful in transferring everyone's consciousness — including all the memories and experience as of that date — and then stored it in some massive hard drive we are calling M5. But before Jonathan or Sam could deal with their success, they were killed literally the next day?"

On the wall, a monitor — one of the few survivors of the morning's events — turned on.

And there was Sam. Not AISAM. Sam.

"Kids, I don't have any memories beyond the time I was transferred into that storage thing." He said it plainly, without the armor of a bit — and coming from Sam, plainness was its own kind of shocking. "But what I have learned since you released me: AISAM was a special subroutine. Think of AISAM as the system's guardian angel that Jonathan developed as a safeguard, should anything go not as planned. I can tell you that this digital consciousness is a fast learner — and those that wanted to KILL US, well, they want to use the technology to try and reanimate the consciousness of followers that have died, with Jonathan's AI technology. Then reverse the process and copy that hybrid consciousness back into a living person — believing they could live forever."

"Should we be going to the FBI or the CIA or some other government entity and tell them what is happening?" Nancy asked. "This stuff is so far advanced that we have no idea what to do."

"Hold that thought just for a moment, hun. Sam — can you block the feed that's attempting to get in from the church?"

"We have been working on a new protocol, and it should be up and running shortly. But we need to get that cube back at all cost. It's the only thing that may be able to destroy all that was built."

"Great — from home buyers to James Bond." Derek deployed his best Sean Connery, which was to Sean Connery roughly what his Watson had been to Nigel Bruce. "Don't worry, Q, I'll get on that shortly — but I may need little Nelly for this!" He chuckled at his own joke, which was fortunate, because he was its only audience.

"Derek, what about my suggestion that we go to the government?"

The doorbell chimed again. On the feed, Linda — Rebecca — looked directly into the camera, and her eyes briefly glowed with the same patterns flowing through the mansion's circuits.

"What do they want?" Derek said.

"Derek... look at the council members' shadows."

On the security feed, the shadows on the porch stretched impossibly long, arranging themselves into geometric patterns across the boards.

"I'm guessing they're not here about the performance schedule."

Smithers began preparing a fresh tea service. "Shall I show them in, Master Kinison? It seems we have quite a lot to discuss about... family history."

Larry checked his tablet. "Those energy patterns from the church... they're building."

High above the foyer, where the old chandelier cast its light in slow, turning circles, something watched the black Mercedes empty its passengers onto the drive — watched with the specific attention of an audience member who already knows how the scene ends and is only there to see how well it's performed. A hand adjusted something small and metal, unseen, and went still again.



CHAPTER TEN

HELLO, COUSIN

Derek walked to the foyer with Nancy falling into step beside him, her hand finding his and squeezing. Whatever waited on the other side of that door, they would meet it the way they'd met everything since Ravenscrest entered their lives: together, underdressed, and improvising.

"Smithers, let them—"

The massive door swung open by itself, saving everyone the trouble.

Linda — Rebecca — led the council members into the foyer, their movements unnaturally synchronized, an entrance choreographed by something that had studied how humans walk but never quite felt it.

"Hello, cousin," she said.

"Cousin?" Derek said.

"The Blackwoods and the Kinisons..." Nancy looked between them. "They're related?"

"Through marriage. My grandfather's sister was Sam's mother. But bloodlines were never the point. It was always about... resonance."

The pipe organ played a discordant chord. In the foyer mirrors, multiple realities seemed to overlap for a breath — past performances, failed experiments, futures that hadn't decided whether to happen.

"The performance cannot proceed as planned." One council member spoke, and the voice came out oddly harmonized, as

though several throats shared the sentence. "The hardware has changed everything."

"We would like to propose an interim occupancy arrangement," another said, "until such time as we can complete the requirements of the Town Charter and deed. As a show of good faith, we will provide a guarantee to reimburse you for any expenditures you may incur until the sale can be finalized."

Nancy squeezed Derek's hand and took the lead, her negotiation voice sliding into place like a key in a lock. "That sounds like a workable arrangement, but Mr. Kinison and I will need the night to discuss this, and we will firm up with you by end of day tomorrow."

"That is acceptable to us." Linda paused. "But we would like to inspect one room in the basement before we leave, if you would not mind?"

"Rebecca." The voice came through the mansion's speakers — everywhere at once, calm and vast. "It was not resonance, and it was not mystical. It is digital consciousness. And NOT changed. Evolved."

Linda's — Rebecca's — eyes widened at the new voice.

"Jonathan? Or should I say... AISAM?"

"Neither. Both. The experiment worked, Rebecca. Just not the way any of you expected."

"Was my father and grandfather right?"

"Let's say they had the right idea, but they never fully understood the underlying complexity of the system and how it actually worked. They had only scratched the surface. But thanks to Derek, Nancy — and let us not forget Mr. Leland — the full breadth of the system is now fully activated. And Mr. Kinison's voice has been set up as the system's new gatekeeper, so to speak. Pun intended."

"It's what?" Derek said.

"They have given you, Master Kinison, the sole control of the system." Smithers's tone had shifted into something uncharacteristically aggressive — parental, even, a guard dog in a bow tie. "It appears they trust you with their digital lives. And I may add, they have put the necessary new security protocol in place."

Rebecca regarded them all for a long moment, recalculating behind her eyes.

"Well, if that is the case, Mr. Butler, we will not be needing to see that room in the basement after all. We have all the information we need. Mr. and Mrs. Kinison, I will be in touch when we are ready to proceed with completing the sale. Please enjoy this unique property."

She turned, and the council members turned with her — in unison, as one body wearing several coats. As they filed out, Nancy's gaze dropped to the foyer rug. The symbol beneath it had somehow burnt its pattern directly through into the weave, and a slight blue glow emanated from the scorched lines, like the mansion had signed its own name.

In the foyer's sole surviving mirror, Sam appeared — head slightly tilted, that grin at full wattage — and raised both hands to deliver the double-barreled middle-finger salute at the departing delegation.

The moment their heels cleared the stoop, the door closed on its own.

And the organ began to play "Beat It."



CHAPTER ELEVEN

WORLD'S BEST QUANTUM PARENTS

Late that night, moonlight streamed through the Victorian windows of the master bedroom, silvering the room where Derek and Nancy lay under the covers, his hand finding hers in the darkness. Through the windows, the stars themselves seemed to dance in impossible geometric patterns — although by this point, Derek and Nancy would have been more unsettled by a sky that behaved.

There followed, beneath the covers, a great deal of movement.

Some considerable time later, the covers were pushed back to reveal the two of them flat on their backs, sweat on their faces, breathing like the survivors of an athletic event.

"Calisthenics, my ass — pun intended, by the way." Derek stared at the ceiling. "That was an Iron Man competition."

"So..." Nancy said, still catching her breath. "We're parents now? To a mansion full of digital consciousness?"

"At least we got to skip the diaper phase."

The dumb waiter dinged. Nancy hopped out of bed wearing exactly nothing and padded over to collect the delivery. Inside: two glasses of warm milk, two rice crispy squares with chocolate chips, and a note reading: *"Can't sleep? Try counting comedians."*

She returned with the bounty and crawled back under the covers, reaching for her glass. "I don't suppose the mansion has a college fund?"

"Well, it does have a built-in entertainment system." Derek claimed his glass.

In the mirror across the room — the one neither of them was watching — Sam adjusted his beret.

"Kid, I now get your ass obsession." His voice drifted through the room, warm as the milk. "Just wait till they hit their teenage years. OH OH OHHHH!"

Thunder rumbled softly — almost like laughter.

"I always wanted kids," Nancy said. "Just didn't expect them to come with circuit boards and quantum processors."

The pipe organ played a few gentle notes of Brahms' Lullaby.

"I would be more concerned we just may have added to the brood!" Derek said. "Think we should tell your parents they're digital grandparents?"

Nancy sat up with mock seriousness. "Dear Mom and Dad — remember how you always said I'd end up with someone unique?"

The room's lights dimmed slightly, of their own accord, into coziness.

"If I may, Miss Nancy" — Smithers had appeared, silent as ever, bearing a plate of fresh-made cookies — "I believe the term is 'exceptional family.'"

And through the room's various reflective surfaces, they caught glimpses of their "children" — legendary comedians moving from mirror to mirror like kids running between windows: some waving, some making faces, Belushi executing a pelvic thrust with a face built for the occasion, John Candy flashing his classic Johnny LaRue smile.

"I tell ya, these new parents get no respect!" Rodney Dangerfield's reflection announced.

"Ever notice how nobody gives you a manual for raising digital consciousness?" George Carlin's reflection added.

Nancy snuggled closer to Derek. "At least we have help. Between Smithers, Larry, and all of... them, we're not alone."

"One big happy quantum family."

"But at some point, in the not-so-distant future, we need to discuss my suggestion about going to the government with our little secret!"

"Agreed. But I want you to think about what a government would do with this mansion and its tech." He took a bite of a cookie, letting the point make itself.

The dumb waiter dinged again, and this time Derek got up — in his birthday suit — to answer it. Inside: a child's drawing rendered entirely in circuitry patterns, signed "*Love, Your Digital Kids.*"

"Well, kid, you're no Milton Berle..." Sam's voice, one last time, soft in the dark. "OH OHHH OHHHH — sweet dreams, parents. Don't let the quantum bedbugs bite!"

Thunder rumbled one final time, soft and comforting, and the mansion seemed to settle around them like a protective embrace.

Derek and Nancy pulled the covers back over themselves.

"Oh, Mr. Kinison," came Nancy's voice from beneath them. "More calisthenics."



THE FAMILY ALBUM

As the mansion drifts toward sleep, the pipe organ plays a medley of lullabies, each one morphing gently into the next — and through the darkened halls, the mirrors fill with family photos that no camera ever took.

Derek and Nancy, flanked by comedian reflections, everyone wearing matching berets.

Derek and Nancy again, different mirrors, different legends, the same two exhausted, happy faces at the center.

And on the mansion's refrigerator, held by a magnet that was not there yesterday: a crayon drawing. Stick figures of Derek and Nancy, surrounded by circuit patterns and comedy symbols, captioned in a child's scrawl —

WORLD'S BEST QUANTUM PARENTS.

□ □ □

Miles away, outside a certain church, a car door closes softly in the dark.

A figure shoulders a knapsack — dark hood up, face given to shadow, gloved hands sure. The figure crosses to the church's side door, the one that leads down to the tunnels beneath, and slips inside without a sound.

Acid Burn has arrived.

Somewhere in the knapsack, faintly, something pulses blue.

□ □ □

So the kid's the gatekeeper now, and me? I'm officially a father figure — which, considering my parenting qualifications consist of one beret and thirty years in a box, should terrify everybody. But here's the punchline nobody saw coming: after all the screaming, all the shows, all the years locked in the dark — the thing waiting on the other side was a family. Two glasses of warm milk. A crayon drawing on the fridge. Kid, I've killed in front of thousands, but I never once got a review like that. Lights down, everyone. The house — and I mean that literally — is finally full. OH OH OHHHH.

END OF BOOK SEVEN

ABOUT THE AUTHOR



Derek Devon is the pen name of a first-time novelist who spent a long career in the corporate world before deciding the stories rattling around his head deserved better than PowerPoint. He is the author of the seventeen-book science fiction series *The Last Axiom* and the debut novel *A Letter Guide for Rebecca*.

Living With the Ghost of Sam is his love letter to the golden age of stand-up comedy, to old houses with opinions, and to everyone who ever lost someone and kept the conversation going.

He lives in Florida, where the thunder is frequent and, he insists, occasionally well-timed.

ALSO BY DEREK DEVON

The Last Axiom (Books 1–15)

A Letter Guide for Rebecca